CS560 - UI/UX Design & Implementation

1-2 Short Paper: Exploring the User Experience Through Personas

Malgorzata Debska

Southern New Hampshire University

Nathan Palmer

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User Persona for Campus Food Delivery Application

Designing an application for campus food delivery requires an awareness of the lives of today's students. Analysis of interviews and surveys conducted demonstrates consistency in students' approaches to food shopping. By combining information from all surveys, we will create a composite user persona which will inform further design decision-making.

Demographics

Our user is about 20-22 years old. This user is an undergraduate student who is usually in his/her sophomore or junior year of college. However, many characteristics of the persona belong to graduate and non-traditional students. According to surveys, 64% of students live on campus while 36% commute to campus. Although students may use the service of meal plans provided by colleges, 71% of students continue buying food outside because of the lack of variety or convenience of the cafeteria. Our users may have to manage several things simultaneously, including studying, part-time jobs, physical training, extracurricular activities, sports teams, etc. Our persona belongs to financially disadvantaged students whose budget is extremely limited. Many of them (41%) have dietary needs due to different diseases, allergies, or ethical views. Using mobile technologies, our users are comfortable with mobile applications for food orders. According to survey results, 90% of students feel confident in using mobile applications for food ordering.

Goals and Motivations

First, our persona looks for fast food delivery. Our user does not have enough time to go to several unusual places to purchase food or wait in line. In addition to the problem of finding a place to buy food, the user would like to save money. For instance, students who have limited resources and pay for food themselves are always concerned about the total expense. Finally, dietary needs are also important since the user must choose products that suit his/her diet. Moreover, some users need to calculate macronutrient intake for weight loss purposes. Social interactions take up a lot of space since many students prefer having food together with other people. Therefore, they need some functions to order food with friends or team members.

Key Tasks

To achieve the stated goals, our user accomplishes several crucial tasks when using campus food delivery application. They include searching for various locations according to location preferences, price, and dietary restrictions. In addition, the user needs information about the availability of various locations at any time. Finally, the persona needs to order food and choose the time when the user will come to get the food he/she ordered. In addition to that, users often order food at a specified moment of time to coordinate with their teammates or friends. Moreover, the user needs to keep track of his/her expense when using the application. The possibility of ordering food with friends also matters to users of the application. They may need help navigating around the campus because of commuting issues or being first-year students.

Frustrations and Challenges

Students face some typical problems related to ordering and purchasing food. First, it is the problem of time constraints. It is extremely difficult to spend too much time looking for suitable food when you have many other things to accomplish. Long lines in a restaurant may result in missing one or two meals, which leads to problems with health. Second, the lack of information also causes a lot of frustration for students. They cannot know how much time the restaurant will require for making an order. Besides, there is no information about location hours. Finally, students need to know about the available food items and prices offered by the company. Third, users of the application may face financial difficulties. Expensive fees, additional charges, and soaring prices prevent students from ordering food and eating healthy. Some of them even skip meals due to financial problems. Users with dietary restrictions need clear information about ingredients or allergens contained in the purchased items. Without knowing that, a student may suffer from allergies or digestive problems. Students may find it difficult to navigate around campus, which takes away a lot of time.

Design Implications and User-Centered Decisions

A lot of design decisions follow the analysis of the composite persona presented above. To help students find food fast and affordable, designers should implement various features into an application. First, a campus application for food delivery should allow users to place orders quickly and easily. This implies such features as fast reloading, quick re-ordering, and easy checkout. In addition, real-time information integration would be beneficial for users of the campus application. It means that the application should provide information about the available items, prices, wait time, and location availability in real time. Another important feature to include in the app is one allowing users to choose food based on their dietary needs or financial possibilities. Filtering and personalizing functions would make campus food applications more useful.

To conclude, users need tools that will help them avoid financial problems. For example, users can track their spending and set spending limits. Budgeting is an important aspect that can encourage students to use food delivery applications regularly. Group ordering functionality would also benefit users. They could order food with their team members and share the payments for the purchase. Finally, it is important to develop such a function that will help students to navigate around campus.